AI2ORBIT — UK Mobile Data Market Report

Pricing · Handset Ex-Factory Margins · Marketing & Market Context | 2026-08-01

SIM-Only Tariffs — UK Market

Headline list prices, mid-2026. Every figure measured. ∞ = unlimited; £/GB blank where unlimited.

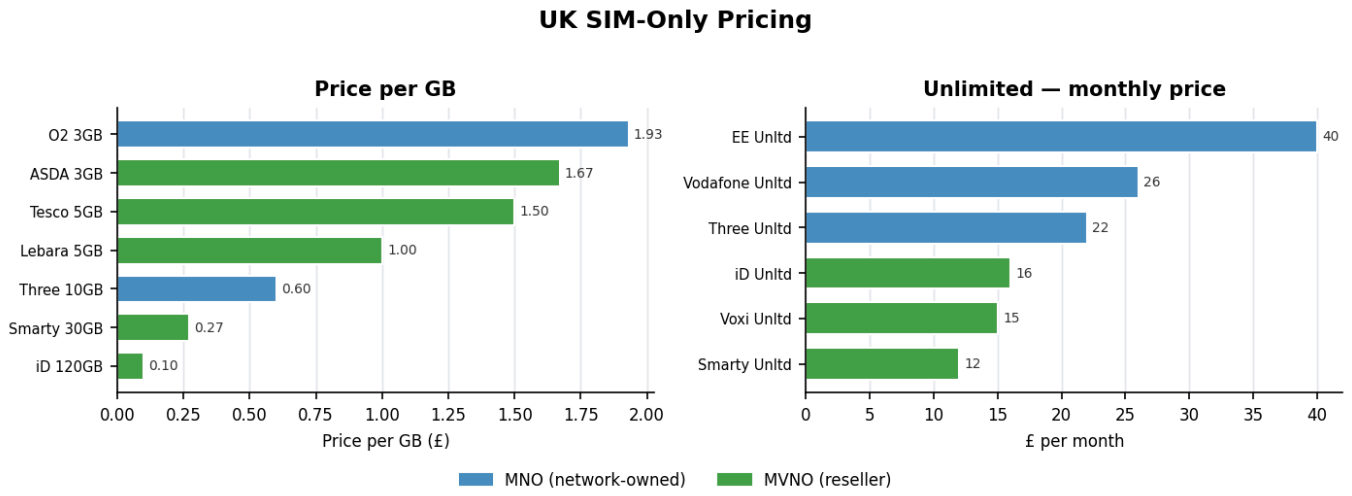
Operator	Type	Runs on	Plan	Data (GB)	Price (£/mo)	Per GB (£)	Contract (months)	Roam EU
Three	MNO	Three	Unlimited SIM	∞	22.00	—	24	yes
Three	MNO	Three	10GB SIM	10	6.00	0.60	1	yes
EE	MNO	EE	Unlimited SIM	∞	40.00	—	24	yes
O2	MNO	O2	Entry SIM	3	5.80	1.93	1	yes
Vodafone	MNO	Vodafone	Unlimited SIM	∞	26.00	—	24	yes
Smarty	MVNO	Three	3GB rolling	3	3.90	1.30	1	yes
Smarty	MVNO	Three	~30GB rolling	30	8.00	0.27	1	yes
Smarty	MVNO	Three	Unlimited	∞	12.00	—	12	yes
iD Mobile	MVNO	Three	120GB	120	12.00	0.10	1	yes
iD Mobile	MVNO	Three	Unlimited	∞	16.00	—	1	yes
Lebara	MVNO	Vodafone	5GB	5	5.00	1.00	1	yes
Voxi	MVNO	Vodafone	Unlimited	∞	15.00	—	1	yes
Tesco Mobile	MVNO	O2	5GB	5	7.50	1.50	12	yes
ASDA Mobile	MVNO	Vodafone	3GB	3	5.00	1.67	1	yes

Read: the cheapest effective data on the market is an MVNO large bundle (iD Mobile 120GB ≈ £0.10/GB); network-owned own-brand plans carry a 3–15× per-GB premium for brand, support and roaming certainty.

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UK SIM-Only Pricing — Charts

Left: price per GB across finite-allowance plans. Right: monthly price of the unlimited tariffs. Colour = network-owned (MNO) vs reseller (MVNO).



Networks & the MVNOs on Them

Four physical networks carry every UK SIM; most value brands ride on them.

Host network	Own unlimited (£/mo)	Value brands hosted	Cheapest £/GB on this network
Three	22.00	Smarty, iD Mobile	0.10
EE	40.00	(EE own-brand only shown)	—
Vodafone	26.00	Voxi, Lebara, ASDA Mobile	1.00
O2 (VMO2)	—	Giffgaff, Tesco Mobile, Sky Mobile	1.50

Sky Mobile + Tesco Mobile alone hold >15% of the consumer segment; VMO2 closed 2024 with 45.7M total connections.

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Handset Ex-Factory Margins

Cost → ex-factory → RRP waterfall

BOM (bill-of-materials) measured from teardown estimates; ex-factory **modelled** at BOM × 1.30 (assembly, test, maker's margin); RRP shown ex-VAT as the trade value. FX £0.79/USD, VAT 20%.

Model	BOM (£)	Ex-factory* (£)	RRP ex-VAT (£)	Gross margin	Markup ×BOM	Basis
iPhone 15 Pro Max	440.82	573.07	999.17	55.9%	2.27×	measured
Galaxy S23 Ultra	370.51	481.66	1040.83	64.4%	2.81×	measured
Flagship (generic)	410.80	534.04	958.33	57.1%	2.33×	**modelled**
Mid-range (generic)	181.70	236.21	332.50	45.4%	1.83×	**modelled**
Budget (generic)	82.95	107.84	132.50	37.4%	1.60×	**modelled**

***Ex-factory is modelled, not a quoted number.** Real ex-factory prices are confidential. BOM excludes assembly, software, IP/royalties, logistics, warranty and marketing — so the gross margin above is the pool those are paid from, not net profit. One constant (EXFACTORY_MULT) re-prices the whole column.

2.3–2.8×
flagship RRP (ex-VAT) over BOM

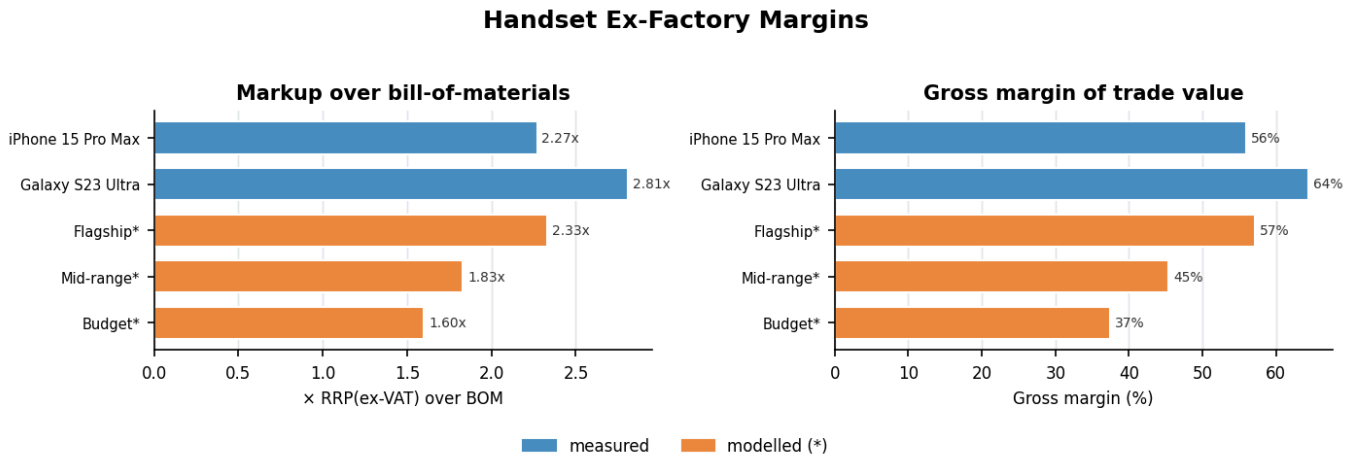
56–64%
flagship gross margin of trade value

1.6×
budget-tier markup — margin thins downmarket

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Handset Margins — Charts

Left: how many times RRP (ex-VAT) sits above bill-of-materials. Right: gross margin of the ex-VAT trade value. Colour = measured vs modelled tier.



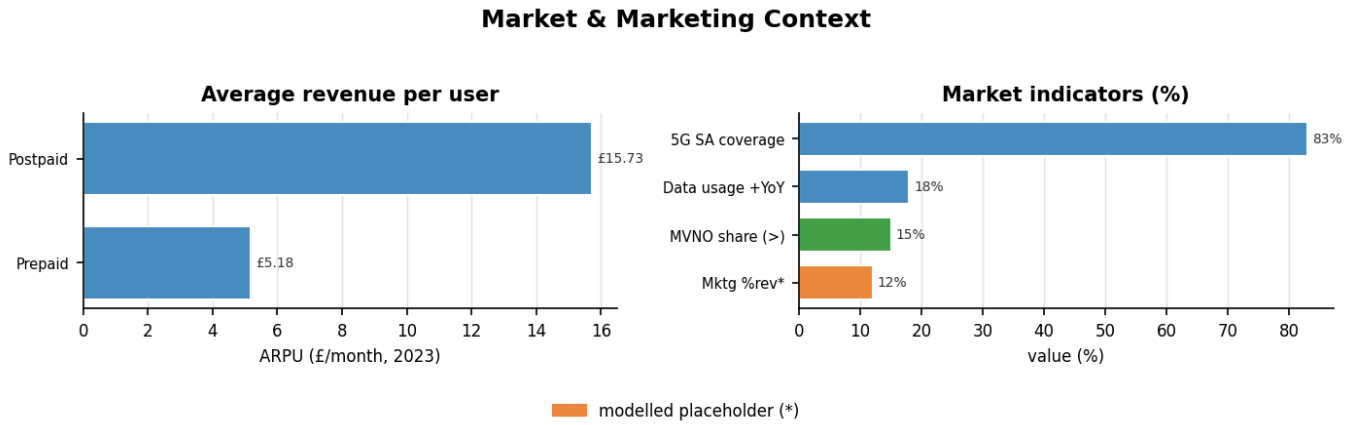
- Flagships mark up roughly 2.3–2.8× their raw component cost.
- The multiple compresses toward the budget tiers (~1.6×).
- Measured rows are teardown-based; the three generic tiers are modelled and flagged.
- BOM is the measured anchor — everything downstream is a stated model you can retune.

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Market & Marketing Context

Where the money and growth sit. The two marketing rows are modelled placeholders — replace with your own figures and they flow through unchanged.

Metric	Value	Unit	Period	Segment	Basis	Source
Postpaid ARPU	15.73	GBP/month	2023	postpaid	measured	Ofcom/Statista
Prepaid ARPU	5.18	GBP/month	2023	prepaid	measured	Ofcom/Statista
VMO2 total connections	45.7	million	2024	all	measured	Virgin Media O2
5G SA population coverage	83	%	2025	all	measured	Ofcom CN 2025
Mobile data usage growth	18	% YoY	2025	all	measured	Ofcom
MVNO consumer share (Sky+Tesco)	>15	%	2025	MVNO	measured	market reports
Marketing spend of revenue	**12**	% (est)	2026	all	**modelled**	placeholder
Cost per acquisition (SIM)	**18**	GBP (est)	2026	all	**modelled**	placeholder



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The Report-Engine Sample Feed

Everything in this report is driven by one deterministic generator so the numbers are reproducible and easy to widen (JSON checksum a792719cdd4e03a6).

File	What it is
plans.csv	14 SIM-only tariffs with price-per-GB
handsets.csv	5 handset cost→ex-factory→RRP waterfalls
market.csv	8 market / marketing metrics
uk_data_market_sample.json	all three tables + meta & assumptions
gen_sample.py	regenerates the CSVs + JSON; `--check` verifies invariants
gen_charts.py	builds the three charts in this report
data_dictionary.md	column-by-column schema + modelling assumptions

Honesty labels

- **measured** — a public / reported figure (see the source column).
- **modelled** — computed here from a stated assumption; not a quoted number. The ex-factory column and the two marketing rows are modelled and flagged.

To make v2 exact

- Your report engine's expected schema / column names — I'll match it precisely.
- Your own marketing figures (spend %, CPA, ROI) — they drop straight in.

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Sources & Method

Measured = reported figure. Modelled = computed from a stated assumption, clearly flagged.

- SIM-only pricing — UK operator price lists & comparison sites, mid-2026 (measured).
- Handset BOM — TechInsights / IHS-style teardown estimates (measured); ex-factory modelled at BOM × 1.30.
- ARPU — Ofcom / Statista, 2023 (measured).
- 5G coverage & data growth — Ofcom Connected Nations 2025 (measured).
- MVNO share & VMO2 connections — market reports / Virgin Media O2, 2024–25 (measured).
- Marketing spend & CPA — modelled placeholders, awaiting client figures.

Modelling constants (all editable in gen_sample.py): FX £0.79 / USD · ex-factory ×1.30 · VAT 20%. Change one and the whole dataset re-prices. This is a sample report — say the word and I'll widen the plan set, add handsets, or swap in your own marketing numbers, at whatever page length you want.

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